it is still nowhere near being finalised.

The MoD's Defence Acquisitions Council (DAC) had shortlisted MDL and Larsen & Toubro (L&T) as the Indian partners for Project 75 (India) in 2020. They were to collaborate with five global submarine shipbuilders. The five foreign OEMs (original equipment manufacturers) include Daewoo Shipbuilding & Marine Engineering (South Korea), Naval Group (France), Navantia (Spain), Rosoboronexport (Russia) and TKMS (Germany). But the programme ran into rough weather due to certain specifications demanded by the navy, including the submarine on offer having an operational or proven AIP module. This left only Germany and South Korea in the race, as none of the others had proven AIP on their platform. Trapped by its own plan, the navy has now asked the ministry to relax the specifications, along with extending the deadline for the shortlisted shipyard to respond to the RFP (request for proposal). June 30 was the deadline, but it has now got another extension of six months.

Commodore Anil Jai Singh, an ex-submariner and vice-president of the Indian Maritime Foundation, believes fuel cell AIP, which the Indian navy is looking for, is critical for any conventional submarine. Incidentally, the navy's new Scorpene class submarines are without AIP. "Even if this programme were to go through (if MoD resolves the issue of AIP), it will be at least 2-3 years before we sign the contract. Then it'll take at least 7-8 years to get the first submarine commissioned," says Commodore Jai Singh. "It seems the first submarine under Project 75 (I) will only come by the mid-2030s. Now, the biggest challenge before the navy is to survive till then because the majority of its submarines are over three decades old and are past their service life."

In view of the developments in India's immediate neighbourhood, analysts say the government needs to take a proactive approach towards submarine-building. The Pakistan navy is likely to get all eight of its Chinese-made submarines in the next 8-10 years, which could put it ahead of India in terms of sea denial capability.

On the other side is China, which adds 20-25 massive ships of bluewater capability to its navy, including four conventional and two nuclear-powered submarines every year. China's PLA (People's Liberation Army) Navy currently has 59 operational submarines. By 2030, their navy will be nearly 450 ships strong.

China is looking at global dominance, and for that it needs a footprint in the Indian Ocean Region. It has already set up a submarine base in Bangladesh

Calling PLA-N's expansion the biggest peacetime build-up since World War-II, a naval officer says, "With their massive numbers, the Chinese will certainly send at least 30 warships including submarines and aircraft carriers to the Indian Ocean. We have to visualise the Indian Ocean Region (IOR) in the next 15 years from now on." He added that China already deploys its conventional and nuke submarines in the IOR under the pretext of anti-piracy missions.

As for our ageing fleet, Commodore Singh says once a submarine is over 25 years, it requires periodic hull surveys to check sea-worthiness. "We are in a grim situation. I don't think our upgraded submarines will be able to take on the new subs (Chinese and Pakistani) that are going to be operating in the Indian Ocean soon. They will have limitations in equipment and other parts," he says.

A naval officer says that though the Chinese coastal mainland is a few thousand miles away from the Indian Ocean, its main strength right now is its SSNs as they can sail all the way from China to the Indian Ocean and continue operating here. "China has got six nuke-powered subs and they are building more, so these boats could become a permanent presence in the Indian Ocean in the next few years," he says.

In addition, the moment China has four aircraft carriers, one aircraft carrier battle group is going to be positioned in the IOR because they do not need four carriers to defend the Chinese coastline. China is looking at global dominance and superpower status, and for that it needs a footprint in the IOR. And the Indian navy is the only force that has the capability to restrict the growing Chinese assertion.

China has a long-term vision for the IOR, having set up a submarine base in Bangladesh in return for giving Dhaka two submarines. They have given the Myanmar navy an old submarine as well. With this, China has got a submarine base in the Bay of Bengal. As for the Arabian Sea, the eight-submarine deal with Pakistan also allows the Chinese to operate in the area.

Experts believe Pakistan, with a small coastline, does not require 11 submarines, but it will be used by China to put pressure on India. "If China wants to contain the Indian navy, they need more than their own capabilities. The hand in glove operation with Pakistan allows them to assert more pressure on the Indian navy at any given time at sea. The Indian navy's pre-eminence as the most powerful navy in the IOR could change if it does not create capability fast enough," says Commodore Singh. The Indian planners need to take an urgent call on building our underwater capabilities before the country finds itself all at sea. ■